

Meeting at Crossroads: An exploration of playful listening through a co-creative AI game

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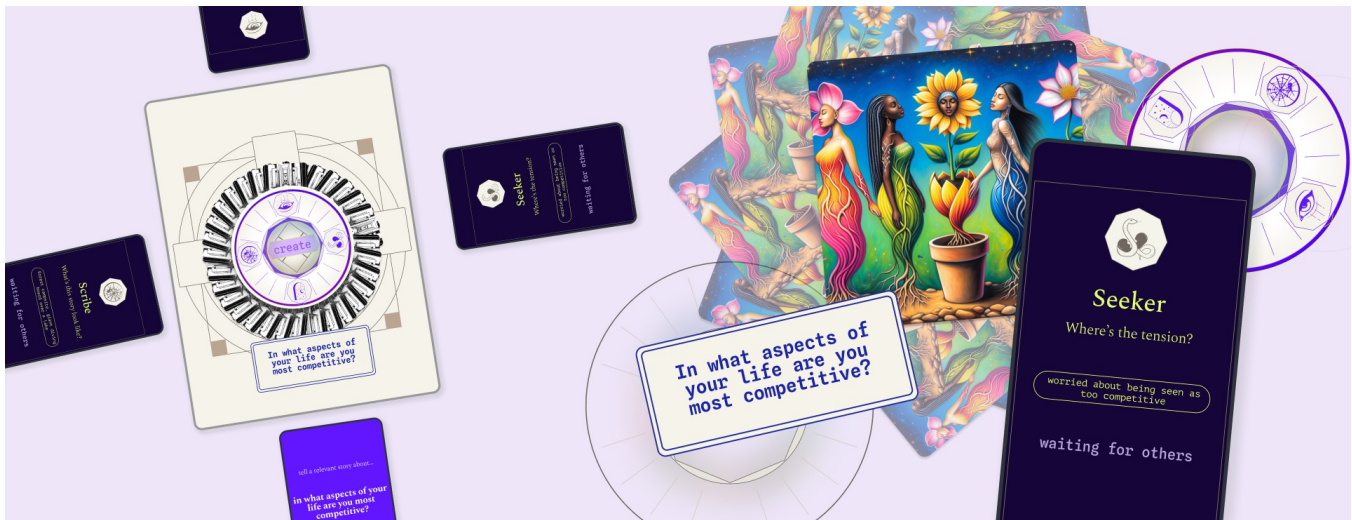


Figure 1: UI components displayed across the tablet and mobile interfaces of *Crossroads* – a co-creative social game which allows a group of up to four players to collaboratively generate images inspired by one another’s life experiences as a way to reach collective understanding. Players respond to open-ended personal questions and co-generate AI images (Dall-E 3) to represent those experiences.

Abstract

Active listening is a well-established cornerstone of empathetic communication and a hallmark of “civic competence”, but is a challenging and energy consuming skill. Games offer a provocative lens to consider how active listening could be explored playfully. In this paper, we present *Crossroads*, an interactive social game which makes active listening fun by inviting players to co-create images about one another’s personal experiences. Deployed through a tablet-mobile web app, players take turns acting in ‘listener roles’ to generate AI images, and eventually uncover a collective picture along a “crossroad” shaped map. An initial mixed-method evaluation with 36 users demonstrates that players find the experience highly engaging and feel especially heard during in-game conversations. This work contributes a novel game which uses AI to mediate

empathetic dialogue, and surfaces questions about the trade-offs of gamifying listening.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Human computer interaction (HCI)**; **Collaborative and social computing systems and tools**; • **Applied computing**;

Keywords

Active listening, Conversation Games, Co-Creation, Generative AI

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1 Introduction

The growing toxicity of public discourse on and off-line reveals a simple truth: conversations without empathy and understanding can lead to profound communication breakdown [8, 64]. One well

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established cornerstone of empathic communication is active listening [34, 51, 53] – a communication act in which a person shows attentiveness and non-judgement through verbal and non-verbal cues. Active listening is thought to be a foundational social skill for developing ‘civic competence’, since understanding different perspectives is necessary to engage with political issues [13]. However, active listening requires considerable effort and skill [8, 51] making it challenging to evoke in practice. Research has shown that web technologies like social media provide little support for active listening, undermining user’s ability to have constructive discussions online [36]. In a period of time marked by deep social fracturing researchers in human-computer interaction (HCI) have taken great interest in finding new ways to design interfaces which specifically facilitate active listening and related communication acts [11, 65].

One method recommended by communication experts is to use playful activities to encourage active listening, for instance through role play or introspective questioning [2, 3]. Since games offer unique environments to explore alternate social dynamics, they form a unique environment which places acceptable constraints on communication and creates a container to depart from everyday speech norms [33, 56]. While it is well established that social games offer powerful opportunities for making connection and sharing stories [31], most games facilitate listening implicitly (i.e., the conversation is not part of the game experience itself). Past work across HCI has explored how specific game mechanics can be used to foster listening-oriented environments, for instance by gamifying psychotherapy [62], self-disclosure [10], encourage intergenerational dialogue [38] and intimate messaging [27]. However, to our knowledge, very few games exist which give players explicit mechanics that make active listening part of the game experience.

In this paper, we introduce an experimental social game which gives players a direct incentive to listen to one another’s personal stories. The resulting game is titled *Crossroads*, a digital social experience where groups of players take turns co-creating images to represent salient moments in one another’s lives. The game deploys two primary mechanics designed to make the experience of listening more engaging and playful: 1) image co-creation and 2) listener roles. In this paper we present quantitative and qualitative findings from an initial 10 rounds of playtesting with 36 users. From statistical insights and rich qualitative feedback, we find that both mechanics offer enjoyable and novel ways for players to engage with each other’s stories, but uncover trade-offs in constraining an otherwise natural conversation experience. This work contributes a novel method for using generative AI to induce active listening in a social game context, but offers insights that can apply more broadly to the design of everyday social technologies. During a time marked by deep social fragmentation, we hope that insights from this project can inspire others to consider how conversation skills like active listening, that are foundational for civic competence, can be incorporated explicitly into social experiences and technology design.

2 Background

2.1 Games for Conversation

Games are powerful mechanisms which can define and influence social dynamics [20, 32, 33, 56, 60]. It is not just that games are fun and motivating ways to engage in social settings; well-designed constraints within the games’ narrative, rules, materiality, and actions create the conditions needed for freedom and vulnerability [26]. While many commercial party games are designed and advertised to help groups of people connect through conversation, they do so implicitly. For example, social deduction games like *Werewolf*, “mind reading” games like *Wavelength*, and party mini-games like *Jackbox*, present players with humorous or fictional situations around which conversations naturally emerge, but don’t dictate or constrain how players should talk about them. A notable exception are conversation prompting games like *We’re not Really Strangers*, which present a series of open-ended questions for players to respond to. Such games have been found to induce feelings of closeness by encouraging escalating reciprocated self-disclosure [4]. While presenting good questions can certainly offer an alternative way to engage, other positive conversation actions like active listening, and asking follow-up questions are not made additionally playful through the game’s structures.

In the broader academic and HCI literature, influential research has focused on how mechanics like synchronicity, mirroring, and coordinated action can induce feelings of closeness [32, 33, 52], but do not focus on specific conversation events or dynamics. Some games designed as part of the serious games literature give players constraints to accomplish certain dialogue ends, for instance facilitating the steps of participatory budgeting [25], conducting interviews with children [61], and talking about Covid-19 [17]. Education games have attempted to teach conversation skills through games [6], and ice-breaker activities propose methods for structuring conversations, often in playful ways [1, 47]. But they tend to follow similar design patterns and do not engage with technical systems.

2.2 Co-Creative AI

Images have a long history of being used to facilitate introspective conversations in and out of game spaces (e.g., art therapy [55, 58], storytelling board games like *Dixit*, divination [15], visual facilitation practice [12, 16], and community organizing [24]). Images are helpful tools to make sense of complex situations, emotions, and experiences because art can capture feelings that are hard to put into words [23], can be interpreted multiple ways, and give viewers a language which is more “ambiguous” than words [22]. With the rise of generative text-to-image models, image-based sense-making systems have inspired design scholars across HCI to consider how the process of making meaning from AI generated images can produce positive conversation effects [29, 40, 44]. For instance, AI image making is used in co-creative futuring workshops [18, 50], collective storymaking for expressive arts therapy [39], and disclosure-based social connection games [10]. Such work takes advantage of the low bar of entry set by AI models, which allows simple text as input [9].

However researchers rarely have attempted to merge concepts from conversation prompting games with co-creative AI. Given that

generated images seem to carry incredible conversation potential [18], and empower a deep form of personalization, there is a great opportunity to consider how the affordances of generative AI might lead to new conversational experiences.

3 Design

Crossroads is a multi-device web interface that allows a group of up to four players to collaboratively generate images inspired by one another's life experiences as a way to reach collective understanding. The game prompts conversation and provides structure to support conversation dynamics associated with active listening (e.g., asking follow-up questions). To begin the game, players sit around a central tablet displaying a website. They connect their phones by scanning a QR code, giving all players joint control of the interface (see figure 2). A spinner displayed on the UI assigns a role to each player at the start of each round. The player acting as the 'storyteller' begins the round by selecting a prompt to respond to. The prompts are open-ended, designed to elicit personal experiences with emotional depth and are inspired by past questions used in past self-disclosure research [4]. After the storyteller shares a story, the other players have 90 seconds to craft a sentence describing what they heard. Each pre-assigned listener role is responsible for capturing a unique side of the storyteller's story (e.g., the sensorial elements, or the conflict). When the time is up, an AI model (DALL-E 3) combines all the responses and visualizes them in a surrealistic image using a technique explored in previous research [37]. The resulting image is a bizarre combination of visual and conceptual ideas that resembles a tarot card [40].

Two mechanics in particular are deployed to induce behavior aligned with active listening: 1) Image co-creation with AI and 2) listener roles.



Figure 2: Play testers playing Crossroads. To play the game four players sit around each side of a tablet, connecting their device to a specific seat by scanning a QR code. Each player shares control of the content displayed in the center.

3.1 Image Co-Creation with AI

Co-creation is often used in connection activities because working towards a shared goal is an effective way to bridge the awkwardness of getting to know someone [10, 54]. Building on a related co-creative intimacy game Closer Worlds [10], we introduced image co-creation into this game to give players a specific and tangible reason to share stories and listen to one another. Related to Seymour Papert's "objects to think with" [48], we were curious if generating an image together could act as scaffolding [57] for reaching understanding and inducing mutual curiosity. Like a classroom 'show-and-tell', an "evocative" [63] image imbued with deep emotional meaning could potentially induce powerful storytelling and an engaging listening experience.

We experimented with several methods to stimulate co-creation around personal meaning, and decided to explore a design where the goal is to create a resonant image representative of each player. To do so, players enter up to 10 words they believe resonate strongly with the current storyteller's disclosed experience. This gives players the chance to reflect and consider how they might translate what they heard into a picture. Players are encouraged to think imaginatively, embrace symbolic references, and be playful with how they choose to represent one another's stories. Our hypothesis was that the process of representing experiential qualities as creative pictures would be engaging, and also stimulate players to listen deeply to what each other has to say, since they are responsible for depicting it later.

After all players have submitted their description, the responses are combined into a single text string which is fed into DALL-E 3 with a style prompt appended. The resulting image appears on screen, giving players the opportunity to discuss the image before moving to the next player. The game ends when all players have played the role of storyteller once, and the center tile "unlocks", revealing a composite image made up of elements from the preceding images (see figure 3).

3.2 Listener Roles

After playing an early version with pilot playtesters, we found that players struggled to make images that were particularly emotionally or personally resonant – instead they felt generic, or story-less. To help give players creative constraints that would encourage them to use more specific visual and emotional language, we invented listener roles that would give players a frame to consider the open-ended task of describing an image. At the beginning of each round, players were given a new role:

- **The scribe:** responsible for faithfully describing spatial, visual, and sensorial details shared by the storyteller
- **The seer:** does the opposite of the scribe by capturing the conceptual and emotional desires of the storyteller
- **The seeker:** depicted by the symbol of a snake, finds the tensions, hidden feelings, and challenges that arose in the story.

The roles were chosen to explore a range of ways that players could pay attention, and ensure that the composite image would contain literal elements mixed with conceptual symbols, a technique refined during the development of another game, Analogia [37]. To further encourage players, we introduced a time period



Figure 3: A screenshot from the 'Crossroads' image reveal conclusion of the game. The image in the center is created by combining elements of the surrounding four generated images (Dall-E 3). Each of the surrounding images was created by combining words gathered from each player in a 'listener role' so that the image visually and conceptually represents what the players were able to take away from the storytellers personal experience. Thus the center image contains some element of all four players personal experiences.

where they were given the option of asking questions to better refine their responses. Our hypothesis was that players would feel pressure to make sure they did not inaccurately depict each other's stories, since they might be called out for not listening. Asking follow-up questions is a well-known way to demonstrate active listening [3, 35, 53], and so we believed that inducing a conversation dynamic that was rich with questions would be an indicator to players that the group was listening to them. When we implemented the design, we found that this introduction shifted the focus of the game towards creative listening, because players became engaged in a novel way. This feature touches on the power of role playing games – by constraining the trait dimensions of a character, players get permission to activate sides of their own personalities [60].

4 Study Methods

This design and research project sought to explore the following questions:

- (1) How does 1) image co-generation and 2) listening roles impact in-game dialogue?
- (2) Do these features feel engaging and contribute to a rich social atmosphere associated with high active listening?

To explore these questions, we created a fully functioning web application and conducted 10 rounds of playtesting with groups of 3-4 per session ($n=36$).

4.1 Participants

Players were recruited as individuals or groups of up to four through an invitation sent to university and local community email listservs. The ad promoted the playtest as an opportunity to get to know other people in your community. Dinner or lunch was served as part of the playtest.

Groups of four were assigned to a session time based primarily around availability. While many social and cultural factors impact a person's willingness to share and actively listen to personal experiences [7, 30, 45, 49], especially prior relationship history [7, 45], given the early stage of playtesting we did not attempt to control for these complicated factors. Since active listening is a highly relevant communication skill across all relationship dynamics, we were open to exploring how the game might apply to a wide range of relationship types. While this choice limits findings, it allowed us to observe how the mechanics are received in a range of social situations and make hypothesis about which dynamics are best suited for the game moving forward (see Appendix A.4 for an overview of participant relationships).

4.2 Study Design

Playtest sessions were conducted in-person in a private university lab space. Since socio-spatial elements largely impact social game experiences [14, 31] the physical space was intentionally designed to feel casual, cozy, and intimate through the installation of soft translucent curtains. The tablet was placed in the center of a small circular table, which necessitated that players sit close together (Photograph in appendix A.2). When first entering the space participants were greeted and players who did not know each other were introduced. Once everyone had arrived, participants completed a short pre-game survey, and were instructed how to connect their phone to the tablet. The first author served as game facilitator, intervening minimally to explain the rules and resolve technical issues. In the case of no-shows, the facilitator filled in as the fourth player and attempted to play with minimal contributions to the dialogue. After the game, participants were asked to give open-ended feedback and complete a short post-activity survey. Both the game session and proceeding interview were recorded and transcribed. Each game session lasted between 75-90 min, with 45-75 min of active game time.

4.3 Measures and Analysis

The following characteristics were captured on 7-point likert scales taken at the end of the experiment to evaluate engagement and conversation dynamics (see appendix A.3 for full question set): Intrinsic Motivation Inventory (IMI) - enjoyment and pressure subscales (6 items) [43]; degree of personal sharing; degree of other sharing; degree of feeling heard, enjoyment of structure, conversation insightfulness, value, and depth. Due to a technical error, one group did not complete a post-game survey.

As noted by other HCI researchers studying intimate social experiences, in-depth qualitative analysis is especially important because of their ephemeral and subjective nature [21, 59]. To analyze the game session recordings we conducted a two-stage qualitative coding analysis [5]. First, the transcripts were structurally annotated to delineate between player cross-talk and in-game speech. Sections of game talk were further organized into **stories** (storyteller disclosure that begins each round), **follow-ups** (listener responses to the story), and **image reactions** (responses to seeing the image). In a first pass of the transcripts, the primary author created a codebook with high-level themes. In a second pass, the themes were consolidated, and a revised codebook was used to update the transcripts with the thematic codes.

5 Results

Overall players have very positive first impressions of Crossroads, speaking at length about how the experience was “very engaging” (P-GZHVE); “combined deep conversation” with “fun art elements” (P-PTUTE); was best-suited for playing with people you know at a “very surface level” (P-UMHUS, P-GZHVN); and “more cozy than a party game [like Jackbox]” (P-YYMYHE). Players rate the game a striking 6.3/7 (SE=0.13) on the IMI Interest/Enjoyment subscale, and 2.8/7 (SE=0.22) on the Pressure/Tension subscale. Critically for this paper’s research questions, the conversation quality measure that players rate most strongly was feeling like they were being heard (6.11/7, SE=0.13, n=26), a sensation that players attribute to various structural elements of the game (explored in the next sub-sections).

However, players do not significantly report feeling that the conversation as a whole was particularly deep or personal. On average players felt they only shared slightly personal things about themselves (4.45/7, SE=0.26, n=33), but felt that other players shared a bit more (5.09/7, SE=0.21, n=33). The conversations were rated as moderately “vivid or engaging” (5.5/7, SE=0.21, n=26) and were seen as slightly insightful (4.8/7, SE=0.19, n=33). Several players (3) attributed their lukewarm perception of conversation depth to the specific group of people they played with, noting that in other social settings (e.g., with friends, co-workers, or roommates) where the group naturally feels more comfortable with vulnerability, they suspect the the stories would have intensified. Some players felt they didn’t get to tell the story they would have liked to (6) because the question that prompted them didn’t resonate with their specific past experiences (3), that the topic was not particularly relevant (2), or that the prompt was not revealing enough (1). Many players (9) commonly suggest to give more prompt options or themes (3) and to “adapt to their moods, level of familiarity, and what’s top of mind” (P-OEWPN).

Players provide mixed feedback on the structured nature of the game, finding it moderately enjoyable (5.77/7, SE=0.16, n=26). Players remark that specific game mechanics create an “air of mystery” (P-PTUTE) and offer “a good excuse to make connections” (P-PTUTS). P-UMJUN summarizes this sentiment well: *“I think [the structure] definitely added a lot of levity. [Without the image making process] I can imagine that thing happening, where someone tells a story and then they stop and everyone just nods and looks at each other for about 30 seconds [...] So [these mechanics] helps you engage with this person, while lifting some of the social burden”*. (P-UMJUN). However, participants note the inherent awkwardness of structured socializing. Players are often under the impression that speaking “out of turn” is forbidden (11), and so they limit their speech out of a desire to not be “disrespectful” (P-GZHVE) or “take away from someone else’s turn” (P-GZHVW). Such feelings potentially signal a need to set more clear “social norms” (P-GZHVE). One player suggests a stronger warm-up might help alleviate the awkwardness (P-OEWPS). In session GZHV, players go further to argue that the constraints on speaking prevented them from taking the conversation deeper as they would naturally in a non-game context.

5.1 Co-Creation

As expected the dynamic between storytelling and image creation was a defining moment of Crossroads, leading players to describe the experience as exceptionally “creative” (P-OEWPE) and a “unique blend of art and deep conversation” (P-PTUTE). The images that the system created were surrealistic and striking (see figure 4 for an example). The moment they appeared often evoked some combination of surprise, affection, confusion, and laughter. Players naturally pointed out general vibes (“It’s giving cult”); evaluated their creation (“We nailed it”); compared it to their expectations (“It’s exactly what I was thinking in my head”); identified with some element (“this is totally me”); or made cultural references (“It’s like Hogwarts!”). Beyond reactions, storytellers often used the image to elaborate on their story (18), because seeing the scene triggered new thoughts or memories. Even misrepresented or missing details drove interesting clarifications (e.g., see transcript excerpt A.3). Similarly, the image prompted listeners to ask more questions to the storyteller (4). Players often tried to reverse engineer image details that did not obviously link to the story (10), and discussed how abstract symbols depicted a non-visual value or feeling (13). For example, P-TUTW related mismatched chairs depicted in the image to the storytellers disclosed value of cultural diversity, making a connection between mismatched dining chairs still making a cohesive set.

While players were able to say something about every image the model generated, it also frequently added content that players weren’t able to explain at all (10) leading to some frustration and confusion (6). Sometimes these “happy accidents” [18] developed into shared jokes that may not have had any meaning in the original story, but were enjoyable to point out and laugh at together (e.g., the addition of a “noir memory thief” in excerpt A.3). Even when the model produced nonsensical images, players (7) value of novel “insight” and “connections” made from the effort of making sense of the “injected randomness” (P-UMHUN), remarking that unintended results could lead to “organic” connections or inspire



Figure 4: One image generated during a game session. This image was created in reaction to a story about a challenging roommate situation one player had in university. In reaction to the resulting picture of an overwhelmed fridge, all players laughed, and spoke in rapid succession, occasionally finishing one another's sentences. Players started by pointing out strange things in the picture they think are funny or bizarre (e.g., pillows in sink), and took guesses of how they all came to generate such a specific place.

“levity” through humor. For this reason, P-TZAZS called the AI “an excitable aggregator of things”. Others describe the AI as “a soundboard to prompt discussion”, or a “tool to dive deeper into whatever that topic or conversation was”. Since the generated image is ultimately used in service of connecting with one another, the process of co-creation and image interpretation were a stronger focal points than how the image looked.

When reflecting on the experience, several users (7) expressed how the visualization of the story shifted the conversation focus towards a “third element” (P-TUTW) or “memento” (PTZAZN). This “guided distraction” allowed players to “let their guard down” (P-TUTW), and learn not only about one another’s personal stories, but about how each person thinks. Critically, for the storyteller, the image acted as a “mirror”, demonstrating that the other players were listening, a powerful feeling, as expressed by P-NZIBW: “[The image] was mirroring my experience very well. And also, it was like, ‘Oh, you guys must have really understood what I was talking about to help generate that.’”

Due to technical challenges, only 5 sessions were able to generate the final image reveal. While seeing the created image in each round was clearly a motivating force throughout the game, the final objective felt “like an afterthought” (P-TGHCS). Players (3) note that they forgot about the goal of the game because it “didn’t

feel like very high stakes” (P-UMUHE), or that they lacked a clear reason why the final picture would be valuable. Although players support the potential of the feature to provide “catharsis” (P-TGHCS), some recommend shaping it around “consensus” rather than reveal (P-PTUTW).

5.2 Listener Roles

In order to generate the round image, listeners are asked to write down 10 words that correspond with their “listening role”. It takes some time for players to do this, and for many (12) it causes some confusion: it’s not immediately obvious how players should strategically allocate their 10 words or what degree of control they have on the resulting image. Most players list a series of unconnected words (e.g., “Family. Ancestry. Generations. Partnership. Deep value of independence.” (P-OEWPS)), or describe a specific feeling (e.g., “Tension of needing things a certain way” (P-GZHVE)). A minority of players get creative with metaphors (“Room that looks like a checklist but slowly to melt away like butter” (P-CVJES)). As hypothesized, the image creation goal prompts players to ask follow-up questions. In 92% of rounds at least one player asks a follow-up question. When posed, follow-up questions are often short direct questions or clarifications (eg. “Where did you live”). Sometimes players use the follow-up as a chance to disclose information about themselves, but mostly players pose simple questions to each other.

Almost all players spoke highly of the listening roles feature, finding it a “fun” element that “add[ed] some playfulness” (P-OEWP). Several felt that going on “listening missions” (P-OEWPW) encouraged them to try on a different “caricature” (P-TGHCN), and see the story from a different perspective (10). In particular the seeker role gave players permission to “psychoanalyze” (P-OEWPW) one another.

However, some players (8) felt the roles were not distinct or purposeful enough. The seer and seeker role in particular felt too similar, causing some to ignore this mechanic by the end. Several players (3) felt overly restrained in their roles, especially while playing the scribe (8). At least three players noted that the writing process felt a little “awkward” (P-TZAZS) for the storyteller, who was put on the spot while waiting for players to write down what they had heard.

6 Discussion

The goal of these playtests was to observe how the image co-creation and listener role features impacted conversation dynamics and begin to assess if and how they are engaging and contribute to the spirit of active listening. The measures for engagement (6.3/7) and feeling heard (6.1/7) were highly rated by participants. The qualitative analysis points to several dynamics which contribute to these relatively high scores.

First, by placing a collaborative activity (image co-creation), rather than simply disclosure, at the center point of a conversation game, players had a novel and motivating frame in which they could speak about themselves which seemed to distract from the discomfort of being perceived. Moreover, the co-creation of an artifact from a personal story acted as an object of communication and demonstrated the group’s collective care and attentiveness. Such feedback suggests that these images helped the group feel

“seen” (ie. be fully and truly recognized by another person [8]. Given the growing desire for more technical systems which embody care, this work presents a possibility for co-generated AI images to play a role.

However, since most of the generated image’s contribution appeared to be shock value, comedic relief, and visual aid, rather than deep insight, it’s worth considering how the AI could be better designed to enhance meaning-making or capture “ineffable states” [40]. It is possible that the content or style of AI generated images is inherently not significantly meaningful, or that the average player cannot make deeply insightful and fun conversation from highly surrealistic images. However, the generated nature of the images appears to offer beneficial affordances. The imposed randomness added friction [42] and ambiguity [22] leaving the important work of interpretation up to the players. Since players felt they could not be blamed for generating poor quality images, they were able to enjoy the process of creation, and have fun in a space defined by safe uncertainty [41]. Future work could further validate these positions, exploring if such a system is able to introduce ambiguity in a way which maintains feelings of agency, a highly topical question given the rapid introduction of AI into all areas of life.

Likewise, the addition of the roles (seer, seeker, scribe) appeared to add playful friction to the otherwise open-ended task of active listening, a design which seemed to empower players to listen, but also introduced additional discomforts. By constraining their ability to listen, players are offered a unique and valuable way to experience the conversation and feel empowered to ask questions they would not ordinarily. However, such a constraint exposes the commonly felt discomfort of ice-breakers and other social games: it is uncomfortable to act unnaturally, even temporarily. While these playtest results demonstrate that structured rules can “lift some social burden[s]” (P-UMJUN) by defining new norms, the activities impose a learning curve around discovering what is acceptable behavior. Players are often concerned about when they are “allowed” to speak or what kinds of questions they “should” ask, signaling they are behaving in more calculated and less fluid ways. However such discomforts do not necessarily signal a failure of these ideas. Instead the emergence of complex social feelings speaks to the power of games to stimulate “critical play” [19]. Sharing personal experiences is itself a vulnerable and uncomfortable process, especially with people you are less familiar with. Designers seeking to make spaces for personal story sharing and active listening must contend with the fact that these discomforts are potentially necessary, and a game seeking to empower challenging communication skills will likely induce some form of discomfort. Future work would benefit from deeply exploring if the supposed benefits of structured socializing out-weigh the imposed awkwardness, while keeping in mind that some discomfort is likely necessary.

Last, a striking detail from the playtests was how the game was able to make space for highly engaging conversations around everyday experiences, rather than flashy, monumental stories. Part of what makes the image creation process effective, is that it requires players to slowly and with great detail attend to random fleeting moments of one another’s lives (e.g., getting to hang your own art on the wall for the first time, or awkwardly asking a stranger to borrow sheets the first night away from home). The slow [28, 46] and detailed attention that a group of almost-strangers give to an

insignificant story defies the observation that media must be highly engaging to entertain and thrill. While some players explicitly tried to tell “interesting” stories, most ended up talking about their overflowing fridge or the view from their bedroom window. That an experience about something so utterly mundane still produced an average of 6.3/7 in overall enjoyment, supports the assertion of Strong and Gaver (1996), that there is real playful and intimate potential in everyday experiences and rituals [59]. However, such a slower pace presents tradeoffs – a great amount of time is spent in silence: players must wait for each other to finish their turn, or awkwardly navigate rules. While it’s possible that additional silence allows for more reflection, designers should critically consider if the silence is contributing to the experience of listening, or if it feels like dead space.

7 Conclusion

In these first ten rounds of playtesting, Crossroads has demonstrated the potential for a co-creative digital game to elicit strong feelings of being listened to while also being highly engaging and playful. While it is inherently difficult to measure the degree to which a conversation is engaging or how well speakers feel heard, especially without a control condition, this pilot study suggests that image co-creation with AI, and the assignment of listener roles are two mechanics which create interesting conversation dynamics aligned with active listening. Future work will attempt to find a strong theoretical framework of active listening to base a more rigorous comparative research study around. Additionally controlling for other social factors that impact a player’s desire and ability to listen.

Although this project presents a conversation game, it demonstrates the potential for interface design more broadly, since playful listening is a timely and widely applicable concept for the development of flourishing socio-technical systems. In a moment where empathetic listening feels strained, we seek to empower future worlds which cultivate human relationships based in authentic, empathetic connection. We are eager to enter this work into dialogue with other HCI researchers that share this aim.

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A Appendix

A.1 Conversational Survey measures

Players were asked to rate their impression of the conversation on a scale of 1 (strongly disagree) to 7 (strongly agree). The evaluation categories were:

- Personal Sharing ("I feel that I shared deeply personal things about myself")
- Other Sharing ("I feel the others shared deeply personal things about themselves")
- Enjoyment of structure ("I enjoyed the structure and pressure to communicate in a certain way")
- Feeling heard ("I feel the others really listened to my perspective")
- Insight ("The conversation activity prompted me to have novel insights about my own perspective")
- Value (-) ("This conversation was not particularly valuable or meaningful")
- Depth (-) ("This conversation felt shallow")
- Openness ("I was totally open and honest in my interactions")
- Hesitance ("We spoke in a way I would normally feel hesitant to")

A.2 Additional Images



Figure 5: Picture of the playtest space. Small circular table was enclosed in a small curtained space to help make the environment feel more intimate.

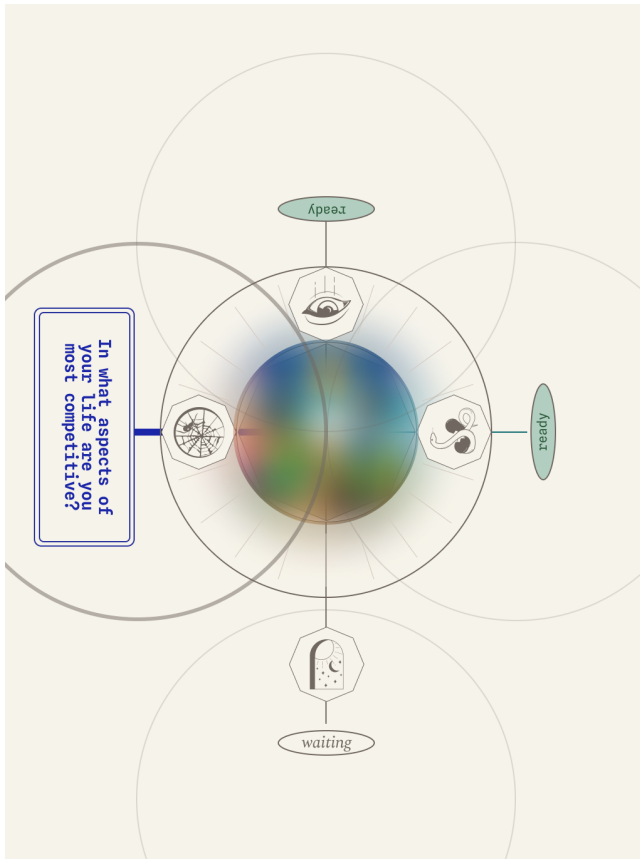


Figure 6: Screenshots from the tablet UI. This screen is shown when players are given a prompt to respond to. Each of the axis display the status of the players. When players enter their contribution to the image, the graphics move inward towards the center, signalling they are ready.

A.3 Sample transcript from the moment when an image has been revealed.

P-TZAZN (storyteller): What's crazy is this is not far off from what my living room looks like [...] But it's darker than I thought. We like it dark. I don't have a lot of overhead lights. (A)

P-TZAZF: I will say I did say punk. I wonder if that was an element. (B)

P-TZAZS: I said noir [...] But it feels very not noir. (B)

P-TZAZN: This is so close to what my actual living room looks like.

P-TZAZS: Is this close to the vibe of what your roommates feel like? (C)

P-TZAZN: Not my roommates, maybe, but the people who hang out.

P-TZAZS: Gotcha. Do you also play soccer in your house? (C)

P-TZAZN: Not inside.

P-TZAZF: No, it's hacky sack. I was really excited to see it, and it's a sentimental hacky sack.



Figure 7: The second image generated in session TZAZ, along with an excerpt of players reacting to the image. The storyteller (P-TZAZN) speaks about the challenges of being sentimental with objects when living in a highly communal home. (A), the storyteller resonates with the image, using it as an opportunity to share more about the space they described. (B), players in listener roles disclose some of the words they used to try to make sense of the discrepancies from their expectations and the resulting image. (C) a listener jokingly uses the image to ask an empathetic question about how other people might feel or use the space. (D): The storyteller reads out the AI generated description which they later note is both very accurate (eg. "laughter fills the air") and hilariously absurd (eg. "a noir memory thief"). (E) Another listener jumps in, using the absurdity as a starting place for a joke. (F) In an effort to make sense of the absurd AI-generated description, the storyteller guesses which character they might be in this silly world. the introduction of a "noir memory thief" by the AI becomes a very lively joke, causing players to hypothesize why an intrusion might have happened, encouraging some players to disclose the words they used to generate the image, and in the end situating the storyteller in the story using a metaphor of "memory thief" to represent their feelings towards nostalgia and sentimentality.

P-TZAZS: Oh wait, that's so sweet. Okay. Actually, very sweet. Oh my god.

P-TZAZN: This is crazy. Oh, description, I forgot to read. "In the dimly lit room of an artsy punk frat house, walls line with shelves holding hidden memories like dusty books. A group of roommates engage in their game of sentimental hacky sack, and their laughter fills the air, as the precious memento is inadvertently kicked into the hands of a mysterious figure. The noir memory thief, hinting at

the duplicate balance between attachment to the past, acceptance of change, and the warmth found in shared experiences. (D)

P-TZAZF: Oh my God.

P-TZAZN: That’s kind of crazy.

P-TZAZS: Congratulations, you have the plot of a novel. (E) [...]

P-TZAZN: Where is the noir memory thief?

P-TZAZS: I wonder if it’s this stoic figure here in the back [...] I did visualize more of someone holding a bag, like a big cloth sack of glass memories in it [...] The duality of that character in the story is really amusing to me.

P-TZAZN: Oh, that character is me holding my memories. (F)

A.4 Participant Sessions

Table 1: Table describing the playtest sessions. Relationships between players are summarized by listing all the types of relationships present.

Session	ID	Players	Relationship	Average Closeness
1	CVJE	3	Friends (3), romantic partners (2), shared grad school (2)	3.3
2	NZIB	3	Casually acquainted coworkers (3)	2.0
3	YMYH	4	Romantic partners (2), strangers	1.75
4	OEWP	4	Workplace acquaintances (3), strangers	2.25
5	TZAZ	3	Strangers (3)	1.0
6	PTUT	4	Casually acquainted labmates and friends (4)	2.75
7	UMHU	4	Former roommates (2), strangers	1.25
8	VRRL	4	Strangers (4)	1.25
9	GZHV	4	Romantic partners (2), friends (2), strangers	2.25
10	TGHC	4	Siblings (2), friends (3), strangers	2.5